

AfterLife: Older Adults’ and Generative AI Use of Their Voice Identity

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Abstract

Generative AI advancements have made it possible to convincingly clone human voices using short audio samples. While offering potential benefits, these tools raise serious ethical concerns, especially when used to recreate voices after death. Despite the growing use of voice tech among older adults, current end-of-life planning and legal frameworks rarely address voice recreation. Little is known about how older adults feel about these technologies or what protections they believe should be in place. This research explores their perspectives on voice cloning, focusing on postmortem use. Through surveys and interviews, I will examine how people aged 65+ feel about AI-generated voices, their ethical boundaries, and desired protections. A comparative survey of younger adults (18–64) will help identify differences in attitudes toward preserving a loved one’s voice. This work stems from concerns in my prior research about older adults’ susceptibility to phone scams and deepfakes, aiming to inform ethical guidelines and legal safeguards.

CCS Concepts

• **Security and privacy** → **Human and societal aspects of security and privacy.**

Keywords

AI-enabled voice cloning, older adults, familiar voice

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1 Introduction

Voice cloning and audio deepfakes are increasingly accessible, affordable, and realistic. Take, for example, the use of ElevenLabs, a publicly available voice cloning tool [3], to impersonate Joe Biden’s voice and target the votes in the New Hampshire primaries with false statements about the voting process [4]. While such technologies present opportunities for innovation, they also raise significant ethical and psychological concerns, particularly for older adults,

whose likenesses may be recreated or misused without their consent, including after their death. There is already discussion about training chatbots on the email inboxes and text messages of deceased individuals so they can forever message a digital approximation of themselves [12]. A similar postmortem use of a generative AI was entertained in a 2025 Netflix documentary. The family of a deceased individual approved the use of her AI-generated voice, yet the broader public response was negative [15].

Familiar voices can be used in persuasive scams, causing emotional distress, financial harm, and privacy violations. These harms are not theoretical: cloned voices have already been used to impersonate CEOs, government officials, and even family members in fraudulent schemes, preying on the victim’s voice familiarity and perceived emergency that a loved one (or precious assets) is in a dangerous situation, in need of an immediate action [6]. These scams are effective, as humans are generally poor at distinguishing authentic voices from cloned ones [24, 25].

Families are left to navigate emotionally charged decisions without adequate guidance, especially regarding the stewardship of a person’s likeness. Lee et al. found that trust in AI clones remains tenuous, particularly when the replication is close to the original [10]. Reproduction of likeness without explicit consent is a problem. OpenAI’s generation of a voice resembling Scarlett Johansson’s, despite her refusal to contribute, is an example of this discomfort [17]. Most people lack the public visibility or legal resources necessary to exert similar control over their own identity. The issue of consent is particularly critical when voice cloning is done without the individual’s knowledge, even more so when the cloned voice is that of a deceased loved one.

Voice cloning platforms, such as ElevenLabs, include disclaimers about authorized use, but there are no guidelines regarding what constitutes authorization, and minimal enforcement is in place to prevent unauthorized cloning [3]. Only four US states have laws that explicitly protect against unauthorized use of biometric data, including voice, leaving gaps in legal protections [11]. Tennessee has gone a step further with the ELVIS Act, which grants individuals the right to control the commercial use of their voice and assign authority over their voice for a decade after their death [7]. Simultaneously, older adults are increasingly engaging with voice-based technologies such as voice assistants. Extensive research has examined older adults’ engagement with voice assistants [16]. These technologies are praised for their natural interfaces and accessibility, particularly among those with mobility and vision limitations. Researchers, such as Pradhan et al., have observed that older adults often treat anthropomorphized devices as companions [16].

As these technologies become more human-like, emotional attachments are growing, raising additional ethical questions when

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synthetic voices have the potential to be modeled after deceased individuals. Amazon, for example, plans to allow Alexa to mimic the voice of a loved one – living or deceased – with just a brief audio sample [1]. This development marked a turning point in how voice cloning might be framed as a means of memory preservation through speech or conversation. Practical use cases like this move the conversation from the realm of fiction into a not-so-distant reality. Here, Lee et al. warned that people share concerns about the commodification of grief, with AI being used to recreate the voices of deceased individuals without a clear ethical framework [10].

The National Institute on Aging offers end-of-life planning resources but, to no surprise, omits any mention of AI likeness or voice cloning [14]. Meanwhile, a 2024 AARP study found that 92% of adults aged 65–74 are open to talking about death, though 50% feel these conversations do not happen often enough [9]. What is entirely missing from these dialogues is the ethical and practical conversation around the use of one's likeness or voice after death. This intersection between identity, memory, and technology demands direct input from older adults themselves. This research aims to understand their perspectives, expectations, and boundaries regarding the use of their voice and likeness through AI, including the potential risk of unconsented abuse of their voice for speech, utterances, authentication, or any identity-related matters that they may never be able to approve or agree to.

2 Research Objectives and Methodology

2.1 Research Questions

My research aims to address the following research questions:

- **RQ1:** What are older adults' perceptions, scenarios envisioned, and emotional responses to AI-generated recreations of their likeness, in terms of voice, after their death?
- **RQ2:** How do older adults conceptualize the ethical boundaries of postmortem voice cloning, and under what conditions, if any, do they consider it acceptable in regard to the use of their own voice?
- **RQ3:** What forms of legal, ethical, or technological protections do older adults believe are necessary to safeguard their voice and likeness, particularly after death?
- **RQ4:** To what extent do older adults' attitudes toward the postmortem use of a person's likeness differ from those of younger adults (ages 18–64)?

2.2 Methodology

To address these questions, I will employ a mixed-methods approach, drawing on my ongoing and previous work. I will first conduct two exploratory anonymous surveys: one targeting adults aged 65 and older and another targeting 18–64. The surveys will include open-ended questions that would give preliminary contours of the domain for subsequent exploration through thematic analysis (e.g., "How familiar are you with voice cloning," "What is your perspective on cloned voices used after people's death," etc.). Participants from both surveys will be invited to participate in follow-up semi-structured interviews. The older participants would be invited to bring in a relative who is in the age group of 18–64, and the younger participants would be asked to invite a relative who is aged 65 or older. I aim to have a pair of participants in each

interview who are familiar with the voice of an older adult so I can develop themes related to both the subject of cloning and the potential recipients of the cloned voice after death.

The older adult from the pair will be offered the opportunity to clone their voice using a local AI model that utilizes their voice reading the Rainbow Passage, a standardized paragraph used for eliciting speech samples (also used in voice cloning challenges, such as ASVSpooof2019 and ASVSpooof2021). I would use a local AI voice cloning model to avoid uploading the participants' voice samples to places like ElevenLabs and preserve their privacy because I will delete the sampling and the cloned voice file immediately after the interview is concluded. For the cloned speech, I will allow the participants themselves to select the utterances to be cloned (in my past research, I have used pre-defined utterances, but since this is an exploratory study, I would leave the participants to select what they feel the most comfortable with for the voice clone to say; If they have no choice, I will offer for them to use general utterances about a will, for example: "My house in the Hamptons goes to my youngest daughter Ashley"). My idea for offering voice cloning is to demonstrate the ease with which one can clone a voice and, with that ease, the potential for (mis)use.

The interview questions will be centered around Hutiri et al.'s conceptual framework about the potential consequences and harms, as well as the social and psychological effects associated with voice cloning. Using their taxonomy, I plan to map the evolving nature of malicious voice cloning and its impact. The goal is to gain insights into the participants' perspectives on the risks of using a familiar voice in deception, manipulation, and emotional harm, particularly through online abuse and impersonation [6]. As this is a narrow topic and involves pairs of participants, I plan to use the concept of *information power* to determine the sample size [13]. Using Braun and Clarke's guidelines on thematic analysis [2], I will situate myself both as an *insider* (in the sense that I work with and encounter cloned voices) and as an *outsider* (in the sense that I have studied voice cloning effects and malicious uses). I will disengage myself from the interview responses, pushing them into the analytical foreground and interrogating them so I can develop a codebook, thematic map, and themes by immersing and critically engaging with the data. Given the vulnerability of the older adult population, every aspect of this research will be designed with inclusion and care at the forefront, following best practices for working with vulnerable communities [18].

2.3 Positionality Statement

I recognize that my identities and my background influence this research project and subjectively bias my qualitative analysis [2]. My active role as a researcher in the process of knowledge production shapes the interpretation of the results relative to our particular social, cultural, historical, disciplinary, political, and ideological positionings. I come from a university in the US; I am a cisgender woman in the 31–40 age range, and I have an educational background in computer science. I have at least 24 months of experience with various types of voice cloning technologies and audio deep-fakes. I am not an expert in legal or policy matters related to voice cloning and postmortem data stewardship. With this study, I do not aim to cast voice cloning technologies in any particular light

but rather to explore avenues of dealing with the potential misuse of one's likeness, especially after one's death.

3 Prior Work and Work in Progress

I am currently in the early stages of developing surveys and receiving IRB approval for my dissertation research. This topic builds on previous work involving misinformation and older adults. Repeatedly, older adults were mentioned in connection with spreading misinformation, especially by younger participants worried about their parents or grandparents [19, 23]. Even misinformation debunkers acknowledged the need to tailor content for older viewers [22]. This repeated theme led to a dedicated study with older adult participants, where many voluntarily raised concerns about AI and deepfakes outside our semi-structured interview questions [20].

In a closely related line of research, I have explored the use of audio deepfakes in voice cloning phishing scams. Our findings show that even individuals accustomed to synthesized speech—such as people with visual impairments—struggle to identify cloned voices accurately [24]. In our research on contextual warnings for phone scams, both older and younger participants expressed concern for older adults as primary targets [21]. I have additional work in progress and under review that continues to explore the relationship between audio deepfakes and telephone scams. In both of these studies, participants have already started to express concerns for the older adults in their lives and the potential for voice cloning technology to be used against them.

4 Expected Contributions

Older adults are both a crucial audience for and potential beneficiaries of technologies designed to preserve connections with loved ones who have passed away. However, these powerful technologies carry significant social and ethical implications, especially for older adults, whose rich experiences and perspectives are frequently overlooked in technology discussions, particularly those involving generative AI [8]. My research is focused on amplifying the voices of older adults, emphasizing both their vocal representations and their active participation in the development and governance of these systems. By engaging with older adults and their younger counterparts, I aim to identify areas of convergence and divergence in their viewpoints. This understanding will enable me to advocate for protections that genuinely reflect their desires and concerns.

My work aims to uncover the solutions that older adults might seek regarding the management of their likenesses after their death. This differs from the management of their data online [5], for example, as older adults have no one to turn to (such as Facebook or social media companies) nor the ability to "fake" their online personas, which is explored and fully understood. Rather than treating older adults as passive recipients of technological innovation, I propose viewing them as engaged stakeholders whose insights are vital for providing meaningful guidance. Their input is essential for shaping policies and tools that are responsible, ethical, and deeply respectful. At the same time, the outcome of the analysis is important in shaping policies or inspiring their creation regarding the stewardship of one's likeness when it comes to the use of generative AI. This effort involves carefully documenting the preferences of

older adults regarding control, consent, and the future use of their likenesses, both during their lifetime and after their passing.

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